In Response to Executive Order 9066 and The Nice Thing About Counting Stars

By Dwight Okita

INTRODUCTION

Ten weeks after the Japanese bombed Pearl Harbor and in an atmosphere of World War II hysteria, President Roosevelt, authorized the internment of tens of thousands of American citizens of Japanese ancestry. In Response to Executive Order 9066 is a poem composed by Dwight Okita in which imagine what his mother's response would have been as a young teen, experiencing the upheaval of her life in the freedom of the United States.

In Response to Executive Order 9066

Dear Sirs:
Of course I'll come. I've packed my galoshes
and three packets of tomato seeds. Denise calls them
love apples. My father says where we're going
they won't grow.

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I am a fourteen-year-old girl with bad spelling
and a messy room. If it helps any, I will tell you
I have always felt funny using chopsticks
and my favorite food is hot dogs.

My best friend is a white girl named Denise --
we look at boys together. She sat in front of me
all through grade school because of our names:
O'Connor, Ozawa. I know the back of Denise's head very
well.

I tell her she's going bald. She tells me I copy on tests.
We're best friends.

I saw Denise today in Geography class.
She was sitting on the other side of the room.
"You're trying to start a war," she said, "giving secrets
away to the Enemy. Why can't you keep your big mouth
shut?"

I didn't know what to say.

I gave her a packet of tomato seeds

and asked her to plant them for me, told her

when the first tomato ripened

she'd miss me.

INTRODUCTION

Roosevelt's Executive Order 9066 authorized transporting Japanese citizens to assembly centers hastily set up and governed by the military. By June 1942, more than 110,000 Japanese Americans were relocated to remote internment camps built by the U.S. military in scattered locations around the country. For the next two and a half years, many of these Japanese Americans endured extremely difficult living conditions and poor treatment by their military guards. The Nice Thing about Counting Stars, however, is you can do it from anywhere . . . The Nice Thing about Counting Stars by Dwight Okita continues to imagine how both his mother and father would have responded to the reactions of the U.S. government to the "threat" posed by . . . not the military of another country, but by citizens residing within the U.S.

The Nice Thing About Counting Stars

"In the hot summers of the 30's, we would

sit on the steps and sing for hours. We

even counted the stars in the sky and it

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was always beautiful."

So my mother begins

writing her life down, Jackie Onassis

thinking in the car behind dark glasses.

She recalls the luxury

of growing up – she and her sisters

buying jelly bismarcks on Sundays

and eating them in the back seat

of their father's Packard

parked on the drive.

Pretending they were going

Somewhere, and they were.

Not knowing years later they would

be headed for just such an exotic place.

Somewhere far from Fresno, their white stone house

on F Street, the blackboard in the kitchen

where they learned math,

long division, remainders,

what is left

after you divide something.

REDUCATIONAL

"When Executive Order 9066 came telling
all Japanese-Americans to leave their
houses, we cleared out of Fresno real
fast. They gave us three days. I remember
carrying a washboard to the camp. I don't
know how it got in my hands. Someone must
have told me – Here, take this."

They were given three days to move
what had taken them years to acquire –
sewing machines, refrigerators, pianos, expensive fishing
rods from Italy. A war was on – Japs
had bombed Pearl Harbor.

Burmashave signs littered the highways:

SLAP
THE JAP

"Take only what you can carry."

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My mother's family left the Packard
And with it left Sundays in the back seat.
Others walked away from acres of land,
Drugstores, photo albums.

I think of turtles.
How they carry their whole lives
on their backs. My neighbor Jimmi
told me one night how they
make turtle soup down south.
A huge sea turtle – take a sledge hammer
to the massive shell, wedge it open
with one simple, solid blow
till the turtle can feel
no home above him, till everything
is taken away
and there is nothing
he will carry away from this moment.

My parents had three days
to relocate.

"Take only what you can carry."
One simple, solid blow –
They felt no home above them.

"We were sent to Jerome, Arkansas.
Arriving there, I wondered how long
We would be fenced in."

The nice thing about counting stars is
you can do it just about anywhere.
Even in a relocation camp
miles from home, even in Jerome, Arkansas
where a barbed wire fence crisscrosses itself
making stars of its own – but nothing
worth counting, nothing worth singing to.

My father remembers only two things:

washing dishes in the mess hall each morning
beside George Kaminishi and

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listening to Bing Crosby sing "White Christmas."
on the radio in the barracks late at night.

One morning, George looked up from a greasy skillet
at my dad and said Yosh, you're a happy-go-lucky guy.
What do you want to do with your life?
It was the first time he realized he had a life
to do things with. He was fifteen. He didn't know.
It was only later that Dad found out George
had colon cancer and had no life to do things with.
And when Bing sang "White Christmas" late at night
Dad could only think, He's not singing to me he's
singing to white people.

My mother meanwhile was in a different camp
and hadn't met my father. At night, she'd lie
in bed and think about the old family car
back in the driveway – were the windows smashed
and broken into, the thing driven away by thieves?

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Or was the grass a foot tall now, erasing the Goodyear tires that were so shiny and new? There was a hole in the week where Sunday used to be, and she wanted jelly bismarcks more than ever.

"Somehow we adjusted. There were weekly dances for the young. Dad sent away for a huge rice paper umbrella of vivid colors, and Peg and I hugged it during stormy days."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

(The Nice Thing . . .) MN State Qualifier

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